

SORCERY ON THE STAGE

magic in Renaissance theater



▲ Dialogue with the Devil

This 17th-century woodcut comes from an edition of *The Tragicall Historie of the Life and Death of Doctor Faustus*. Marlowe's salutary tale features a doctor hungry for occult knowledge, who turns necromancer and sells his soul to the Devil.

In Renaissance theater, magic was used to entertain, supply convenient plot devices, and reflect back to the audience an important part of their culture. Playwrights explored how the theater's illusions echoed real life, and whether theater itself was a kind of magic.

Comedy magic

In 1499, *Celestina*, a comic dialogue by Spanish writer Fernando de Rojas, was published. Its pivotal character, Celestina, is a sorceress—topical and risky at a time when the

Spanish Inquisition was actively prosecuting perceived sorcery. This work passed muster with the Inquisitors, however, who merely deleted some anti-clerical lines.

The astrologer-necromancer-charlatan figure was a popular stock character in comedy. The magician Ruffo in the 1513 comedy *La Calandria* by Italian Cardinal Bibbiena was a typical example. Illusion and transformation are central both to Ruffo's activities and to the other characters' tangled and humorous misunderstandings.

By the mid-17th century in France, magic was often a marker for tragi-comical and Baroque theater styles, as opposed to classical traditions. In *L'illusion comique* by Pierre Corneille, the presence of its magician, Alcandre, ties in with the play's clever “play within a play” device and groundbreaking inquiry into the slipperiness of appearances.

“Magus, whose studious toil,
by night, gives way to a fresh
spate of miracles each day.”

DORANTE ON ALCANDRE IN CORNEILLE'S *L'ILLUSION COMIQUE*, 1635–1636

Light and dark

In English Renaissance drama, magic was used for comedy, clever invention, and light entertainment, as well as for darker themes. Playwrights often sought to keep on the right side of the reigning monarch, however. Under James I, this meant pandering to his anti-witchcraft fervor. Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus*, published in 1604, the same year as James's draconian Witchcraft Act, offered a portrayal of the occult that terrified audiences into thinking they saw real devils on the stage.

Shakespeare also partly went along with James I's notions of witchcraft with his stereotyped hags in his play *Macbeth*. But his depiction of sorcery was often subtle, as in *A Midsummer Night's Dream* or *The Tempest*, whose magician, Prospero, may have been modeled on the real-life occultist John Dee.

IN PRACTICE

In the name of love

Renaissance theater often used a sprinkling of magic or the supernatural when dealing with themes of romance, such as conquering the object of one's love or bringing together star-crossed lovers. This device reflected the fact that popular magic had long been filled with folk spells and potions that could be used to gain one's heart's desire. The flower juice in Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream* (see p.173) was modeled on concoctions made from real-life herbs such as blue vervain.

Blue vervain was used in love potions to rekindle a dying love or woven into bridal wreaths.

